

Written by Kanu Behl and Atika Chohan, ***AGRA*** stars Priyanka Bose and Rahul Roy. It releases in theatres on Nov. 14

THE RAW **TRUTH**

Actor Priyanka Bose returns to independent cinema with* Agra*, a haunting exploration of desire, repression and the messy truths of being human

Priyanka Bose has always been drawn towards stories that "don't try to 'neaten' the chaos of being human". "Independent cinema gives me that freedom—to question, to fail, to be messy, to not have all the answers," affirms the actor, known for her roles in films such as *Love Sex Aur Dhokha*, and the Oscar-nominated *Lion*.

This quest continues in her latest project, *Agra*, a stark, unsettling portrait of a young man's sexual awakening and emotional confinement within the claustrophobic walls of his family home. Bose believes that her role of Priti—an older woman with a limp who runs an internet café and becomes entangled in a fragile, unsettling relationship—exemplifies how discomfort can reveal deeper truths. "I don't see discomfort as something negative anymore; it's just another way of finding honesty," she elaborates. "When you strip away all the machinery of big productions, what's left is just you, the character, and the camera—and that's an incredibly intimate space...."

Agra had its world premiere at the Cannes Film Festival in 2023 and has been wowing audiences globally since then. Written by Kanu Behl and Atika Chohan, the film also stars *Aashiqui* actor Rahul Roy. It is set to release in theatres on November 14. ■

—Deepa Natarajan Lobo

MOUNTAINS, MEMORIES, **MOVING IMAGES**

***THE DHARAMSHALA INTERNATIONAL FILM FESTIVAL* RETURNS WITH A FINELY CURATED SELECTION OF PERSONAL, POWERFUL STORIES FROM SOUTH ASIA AND BEYOND**



With Mumbai's MAMI film festival cancelled, the Dharamshala International Film Festival (DIFF) is set to be the first major film fest this season. Organised by Dharamshala-based filmmakers Ritu Sarin and Tenzing Sonam, it will take place within the Tibetan Children's Village in Mcleodganj. As always, the festival is non-competitive, committed to featuring high-quality South Asian titles with a bent towards personal storytelling.

Among the highlights in the features section is Bhutan's entry for the Oscars, Dechen Wangmo Roder's *I, The Song* (left), which has a schoolteacher seeking out her doppelgänger after a viral video jeopardises her job and reputation.

The tale of another schoolteacher is a must-watch: Nidhi Saxena's *Secret of a Mountain Serpent*. Premiered at the Venice Film Festival, it won the Biennale College Cinema Fund; Saxena is the first Indian woman to receive this grant. Set in a remote Himalayan town in the '90s, Saxena's film tracks a married teacher who gets drawn to a mysterious outsider disrupting the myths and silence of her village.

Among international titles, Rich Peppiatt's acclaimed comedy drama and Ireland's Oscars 2026 pick, *Kneecap* (below) is to watch out for. Also don't miss Carla Simón's Palme d'Or-nominated *Romería*, which follows its 18-year-old female protagonist as she travels to learn about her estranged father, who died of AIDS. In docufiction, there's *The Wolves Always Come at Night*, which highlights the travails of a Mongolian shepherd family. ■

— Devarsi Ghosh

FILM FEST
DIFF 2025 will take place from Oct. 30-Nov. 2 in Mcleodganj

